

Exchanging words

Document editing tools: getting your documents to look the way you want them on your handheld has never been easier

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When it comes to the utility of a handheld device, its power lies not in its ability to store numerous contacts, phone numbers and schedules but in the fact that it can be used to help you get work done while you're on the move. At the office and home, the primary use of most desktop PCs is for creating documents, which would include files created from applications such as word processors, spreadsheet files and presentations.

While the handheld computers available today have the processing power to allow you to edit documents on the move, the main hindrance here has been that of entering large amounts of text into your handheld. While the handwriting recognition capabilities of these devices has increased exponentially in power and accuracy, the form factor of the device makes it unsuitable for entering large amounts of data. However, with the advent of portable keyboards that can be connected to your handheld, this problem has been overcome. The limitation with most handheld devices is the fact that the display and memory on the devices cannot handle very large amounts of document data, especially when special formatting or multiple fonts are used. For example, in older Palm devices, the screen resolution isn't high enough to display special types of fonts and

graphics. Also, the integrated application for text editing on your Palm, for example, is the MemoPad. While this Spartan tool is easy to use, there are glaring disadvantages in that the maximum size of each memo is just 4 KB. Also, this editor uses the standard ASCII character set and, therefore, no special fonts and formatting options are available. To overcome some of these limitations, the DOC format was initiated for the Palm, allowing for much larger documents. However, the formatting capabilities were still very limited.

Hence, to view the documents created on your desktop on your handheld, they would need to be ported into a special format that can be recognised by the handheld. That's where the text editing and document readers for handhelds come into play. These applications read your source documents (be it Excel Spreadsheets, Word files or even PowerPoint presentations) and convert them into a format that can be displayed on your handheld while retaining as much of the formatting as possible. There are also programs such as WordSmith that let you maintain the fonts used in your original files and view them on the handheld. This is also a very capable word processing application for your Palm. It lets you create and edit documents with fonts and formatting where the size is limited only by the amount of free memory on your device. After working on the document, the formatted information and even the fonts are retained so that when you transfer them back to your PC, the document maintains this information.

There are numerous other applications that let handheld users transfer files from the desktop to the Palm, which can later be edited and worked on while on the road.

With these applications, you

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